

Palit N73PV

Aged nForce Powered Entry Level Board

The Palit N73PV is a micro-ATX format LGA775 motherboard for Intel processors. It's based on the nForce 610i chipset and uses the GeForce 7100 as the graphics solution. It has native support for 1333 MHz processors, so the Core 2 Duo E6x50 processors will run without the need to flash the BIOS.

The focus is on being an entertainment board—it features a DVI-D port and a 7.1 channel Realtek HD audio onboard sound card.

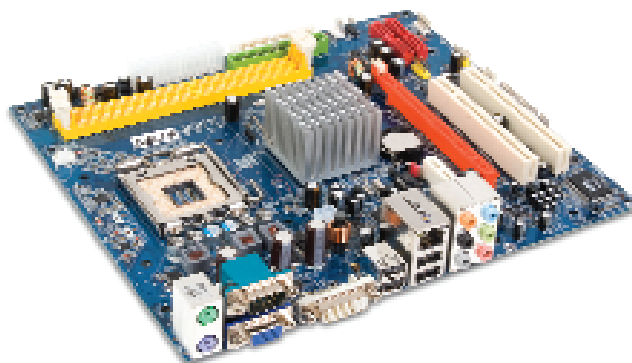
The onboard graphics solution isn't great, with *Doom 3* giving frame rates in the 20s on medium settings and low resolutions. There is a PCIe 16x slot and two standard PCI slots for any

upgrading that you might want to do. There are only 2 DIMM slots, which means you can't plug in more than 2 GB of RAM.

The layout of the board is compact, and there are no major flaws with it. A graphics card with a large cooler could render the adjoining PCI slot useless leaving only 1 slot for expansion—a TV tuner card for example. Luckily, the SATA ports have no such issues. The bundle is extremely basic, and there

RATINGS

Features	★★★★☆
Performance	★★★★☆
Bundle	★★★☆☆
Value for Money	★★★★★
Overall	★★★★☆



is no supplied software other than the necessary drivers for the board.

For users who are looking for performance in a gaming machine, there are cheap P35 based motherboards available starting from around Rs 4,500 which would make a better buy than the Palit N73PV. The price for this motherboard is a mere Rs 2,950 which makes it ideal for anyone building a HTPC, or maybe just a PC for

regular use with an extremely tight budget.

Specifications

NVIDIA MCP73PV, Upto 1333 MHz FSB, Socket 775, 4 SATA ports, Realtek ALC883 7.1 Channel Audio, Realtek Gigabit network controller

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Price: Rs 2,950

Intel Core 2 Duo E8500

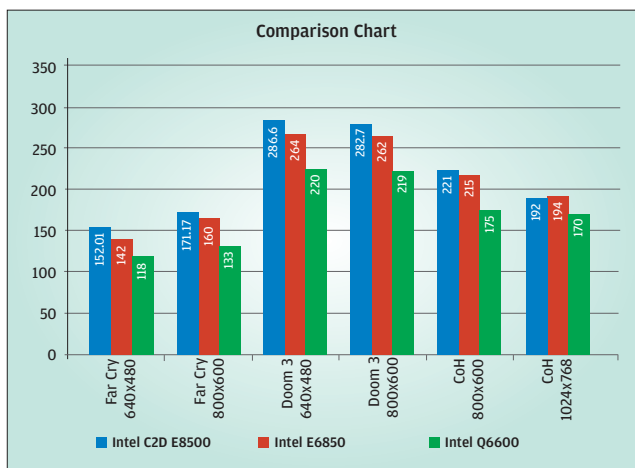
Leader Of The Wolf Pack

It's all afterburners on at Intel with their aggressive assault by releasing the Wolfdale line of processors. It's an unexpected release, and there hasn't been enough action from the AMD Phenoms that released at the end of last year. Things have definitely not gone as planned. The E8500 is the spearhead processor of this new attack early in the year. One of the biggest changes in these processors is the move to 45nm fabrication process, which means cooler processors. The other changes in the E8500 are the 6 MB L2 cache (up from 4 MB) and the core speed—a dizzying 3.16 GHz.

All the synthetic benchmarks showed the expected boost in scores. The real-world rendering benchmark—Cinebench—also gave a fairly large increment in performance in rendering but the benefit of the two

additional cores on the quad core cannot be matched with a dual core processor just yet even with such a fast core. This means even the low-end quad core Q6600 shoots ahead in the rendering and video encoding tests. For gaming, the quad core is no match for the E8500 because games hardly exploit the four cores. The temperature, despite higher ambient temperatures, was just around 50 degrees C after some heavy benchmark bombardment.

The performance increase throughout all the benchmarks from the E6850 is more or less 10-15 per cent, while the processors are all priced in the market at pretty much exactly the same as the earlier Core 2 Duos. The new processors then become better value for money. Anyone planning on upgrading to an E6850 should switch tracks and go for the E8500 or the other



E8xxx processors—they're faster, cooler and much better bang for the buck. The games that make proper use of quad cores processors are still awaited, and until they arrive, the E8500 is an excellent choice for gaming rigs. Prices for the E8500 should be around Rs 13,000.

